

Strategic Planning Definitions¹

COMPONENTS OF THE STRATEGIC PLAN

Mission	The mission of an organization is a statement of the purpose of the organization - why the organization exists. Mission statements include what an organization does and for whom . Mission statements may also include why or how an organization does its work.
Vision/Aspirations	The vision of an organization describes what will be different as a result of the organization achieving its mission. Vision may be short and concise like a book-end to the mission statement. Or, a vision may be detailed and include how the organization will impact key constituencies and what the organization will look like.
Goals	Goals describe what the organization intends to achieve within the timeframe. Strategic plans should generally include 4-6 goals. Goals should be broad and have relevancy over a multi-year period. Typical goal areas include the following areas: 1. Improve program effectiveness, quality, results and/or innovation 2. Expand programs, develop new program areas 3. Expand client/participant/member engagement, community engagement 4. Improve external relations (such as advocacy, partnerships, collaboration, etc.) 5. Expand and diversify revenue 6. Strengthen the organizational infrastructure (may include strengthening board of directors, staff recruitment/retention, technology, marketing/PR, etc.)
Objectives	Specific targets for each goal area. Each goal area may have 3-6 objectives. Objectives should be concrete, measurable and achievable. For example, if the goal is to increase community engagement, objectives may be to a) hold four stakeholder meetings per year and b) launch an online discussion forum.

¹ Adapted from "Strategic Plan Outline," Maryland Nonprofits

STRATEGIC PLAN IMPLEMENTATION

Actions	Specific tasks that will be carried out in reaching objectives
Deadline/Timeline	A broad timeline may be appropriate for a strategic plan indicating years or quarters when certain objectives will be achieved, or if certain actions will not begin until an out year, that may be indicated in the plan. Detailed timelines are not recommended for a multi-year strategic plan since so many variables can change from year to year. Detailed timelines should be developed on an annual basis as part of an annual plan, closely tracking to the strategic goals and objectives.
Persons Responsible	Again, responsibility for actions should be included in annual plans, usually not in the multi-year strategic plan, as staffing and organizational structure may change to meet changing needs.
Cost	Organizations may choose to create a multi-year financial projection based on the strategic plan. The board should formally approve the one-year budget as it normally does, and use the multi-year projection as a guide.

ASSESSING PROGRESS

Expected Outcomes	Specific outcomes expected to be achieved through successful completion of goals and objectives. This section may include a list of measures to be established and reported on regularly showing steady improvement or specific targets, such as: • Satisfaction of program participants improves each year • Number of participants/donors/members, etc. increases by 10%. • Number of program participants that achieved their goals increases each year (i.e. got a job, completed a project, learned a new skill).
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